

shared all over the web like wild fire. Even someone who's not very entrenched in this culture would have surely come across some memes. Lolcats is a perfect example. After that first fateful image appeared on icanhazcheezburger.com, it almost seems like kittens have taken over the internet. There've been images, comics, an entire grammatically absurd language, videos and lots of other content produced to the theme of lolcats.

There's no stopping the phenomenon! Memes crop up everyday at places like 4chan which then get regurgitated on to reddit and then onward to curating web sites such as funnyjunk and 9gag. To be into this culture is to literally be in touch with the pulse of the internet. Text from memes gathers meaning and weight as it passes along from one user to another. Such text can be used in context and you'll need to be into the culture to understand it fully. Take the following conversation into the picture:

Dude: Irrc this one web site I came across derps a lot, check this out: <http://derp.org/derpi>

Troll: glorious exposition comrade . tldr.

There are at least two memes and lots of l337 speak. Head over to <<http://bit.ly/cultmeme>>

Tech fitness culture

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LOLCATS, taking over the world one cat at a time

is becoming a big culture in the west. Yuppy geeks all over the world are enthusiastically using their phones and accessories to track, examine, monitor and prevent problems and improve their health. According to MobiHealthNews, Apple's App store alone offers over 9000 mobile health apps and these are expected to grow substantially. Similarly there are countless other apps available on the Android market too. Such apps spans a wide breadth of areas including cardio fitness apps, apps that help you stick to a diet, cope with stress, give up smoking and regulate your lifestyle.

It's not just apps that will drive this culture though. Already there are accessories (basically sensors) such as the recently released Jawbone UP that are entering the fray. The UP is a wristband accessory that syncs with an iPhone app and tracks vital health stats of the wearer such as motion, sleep patterns and eating habits. The band vibrates to remind users of inactivity and other important tracking parameters. There's also a social angle to the app, whereby users can compete against others. There are leaderboards, unlockable achievements and rewards. Digifit is another sensor accessories provider with a slightly specialised offering for runners and other sports enthusiasts to monitor their heartrate, strides etc. Going beyond apps and wearable sensors there's even news of Ford launching in-car health monitoring services under the Ford SYNC banner. Ford researchers demonstrated a series of possible in-car health and wellness connectivity services to help people with chronic illnesses or medical disorders such as diabetes, asthma or allergies manage their condition while on the go. Apart from these, exergaming / motion gaming has been adding a layer of entertainment to your daily fitness needs for quite some time now with no signs of slowing down. The geeks who are to inherit the earth will no longer be a race of puny intellectuals. We'll soon be looking at a technology-enhanced super geek...

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Jawbone UP

That creepy feeling

"All my life I've had this strange feeling that there's something big and sinister going on in the world", proclaimed Arthur Dent in the *Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*. Another character in the book explains to him that the feeling "is just perfectly normal paranoia".

Is a certain amount of paranoia normal or is there really something sinister going on behind the scenes that the general populace has been purposefully kept unaware of? The conspiracy culture of which many a geek is part of professes that there is. Geeks from all over the world spend countless hours clutching at various subliminal clues that they feel will unearth some profound mystery only if they look hard enough. There are conspiracies about the 9/11 terror attack, UFO cover-ups, presidential assassinations and even absurd theories that suggest *Harry Potter* is about homosexuality.

Any rational person would probably peg most of these as just flights of fancy. However, thousands of other rational people consumed by their obsession offer up what they feel is conclusive evidence confirming the existence of said cover-up. Most of it is junk and the evidence is usually the result of people drawing patterns where there are none or patterns emerging because thousands of permutations and combinations are bound to create some linkages. It's like staring at a wall and seeing what you want to see.



They live among us... and are probably procreating

At the same time, geeks have been able to uncover several instances of covert action and fudging in the recording of history. Conspiracy is very much a part of geek culture and makes for an interesting hobby. But beware it can consume you. <<http://bit.ly/cultconsp>> 